2026 Designation Application Announcement for Distinguished Research Institute Companies (Rising Star·Star) by Growth Stage

To promote continuous growth and excellent outcomes of research institute companies within the research and development special zone, and provide tailored nurturing support according to growth stages and company characteristics, we hereby announce the "2026 Designation of Distinguished Research Institute Companies (Rising Star·Star) by Growth Stage". Research institute companies with growth potential and technology commercialization capabilities are invited to apply according to the related procedures.

September 9, 2026

Vice Prime Minister and Minister of Science and ICT Kyung Hoon Bae, Chairman of the Research and Development Special Zone Promotion Foundation Hee Kwon Jung

Ⅰ Designation Outline

■ Purpose of Designation

◦ Designate research institute companies with outstanding growth potential (growth stage, technology commercialization performance, etc.) as 'Rising Star' and 'Star' and promote continuous growth through tailored support for each stage.

◦ Identify promising research institute companies equipped with competitive technology and products early on, and intensively support technology scale-up, investment, and global expansion to nurture them into deep tech anchor companies representing regions and the nation.

■ Classification of Designation

Category	Rising Star Research Institute Company	Star Research Institute Company
Definition of Designation	Promising research institute companies equipped with technology (products) and corporate capabilities, with expected market growth.	Outstanding research institute companies with expected global market expansion and scale-up based on commercialization performance and market competitiveness.
Designation Criteria	Set differentiated quantitative and qualitative designation criteria according to the technology commercialization stage and growth characteristics of research institute companies (※Refer to 'Evaluation Criteria')	
Scale of Designation in ’26	Approximately 10 companies	Approximately 2 companies

※ If there are no suitable companies, fewer than the designated scale may be selected as evaluation results.

※ The same company cannot apply for both Rising Star and Star Research Institute Company, and should choose one sector considering the company's growth stage and designation criteria.

■ Project Implementation System (Detailed task composition as an example)

Ministry of Science and ICT

		Announcement and management supervision of designation plan		
		Research and Development Special Zone Promotion Foundation Specialized Institution		

Evaluation Committee (New/Final Evaluation, etc.)

Rising Star Research Institute Company	(Collaboration)	Star Research Institute Company	(Collaboration)	Honorary Research Institute Company (Graduation)
Designation of Outstanding (Rising) Research Institute Company		Designation of Outstanding (Star) Research Institute Company		Designation of Honorary Research Institute Company

Ⅱ Eligibility and Designation Criteria

■ Common Eligibility

◦ Companies maintaining their status as a research institute company under Article 9-3 and Enforcement Decree Article 13 of the "Special Act on the Promotion of Research and Development Special Zones", as of the announcement deadline.

* Companies categorized as or cancelled from registration based on the research institute company registration requirements as of the application deadline are not recognized.

◦ Companies meeting the minimum quantitative criteria for each 'Rising Star' or 'Star' research institute company below.

※ Applicant companies should be able to objectively prove whether they meet the quantitative criteria of the applied designation sector with evidence.

■ Rising Star Research Institute Company

• (Target for Designation) Research institute companies equipped with competitive technology and products and corporate capabilities, with expected growth through future market entry, sales and employment expansion, and additional investment.

• (Eligibility (Minimum Quantitative Criteria)) Must meet at least one of the following criteria:

1. An average annual sales of 1 billion KRW or more over the last three fiscal years* 2. An average annual sales growth rate of 15% or more 3. A cumulative investment attraction amount of 2 billion KRW or more after registering as a research institute company 4. Achievement of certification/awards such as NET·NEP certification, venture company confirmation, CES Innovation Award, etc., proving technology * Recognized only when appropriate supporting documents, such as NET, NEP, Excellent Procurement Product, Innovative Product, G-PASS, Venture Certification Company, CES Innovation Award Certificate, are submitted.

* However, for companies with fewer than 3 fiscal years, the average annual sales and annual sales growth rate are calculated based on the fiscal years completed since establishment. The annual sales growth rate is applicable only when there are sales records for at least 2 fiscal years.

※ Recent 3 years ('23~'25) sales and average annual sales growth rate are calculated based on the confirmed financial statements of the applicant company.

※ The amount of investment attraction is based on the actually completed paid-in investment from external professional investment institutions, and related evidence must be submitted.

※ The recognition scope for technology proof achievements can be verified in the pre-screening process based on the submitted materials.

• (Scale of Designation) Selection evaluation (document→presentation) / Final support for up to 10 companies

* The scale of designation is confirmed only for '26 and can be changed depending on the evaluation and deliberation results.

* About 50% of the applicant companies can be selected for follow-up (presentation) evaluation through document evaluation.

■ Star Research Institute Company

• (Target for Designation) Research institute companies in the stage of growth verification, where business performance such as sales and investment attraction is confirmed in the market, with expected subsequent investment and market expansion based on the competitiveness of owned technology and products.

• (Eligibility (Minimum Quantitative Criteria)) Must meet at least one of the following criteria:

1. Average annual sales of 5 billion KRW or more for the last three fiscal years ('23~'25) with an average annual sales growth rate of 20% or more 2. A cumulative investment attraction amount of 5 billion KRW or more after registering as a research institute company

※ Both conditions of sales and sales growth rate for the last 3 years ('23~'25) must be met to satisfy a single quantitative criterion.

※ Sales and sales growth rate are calculated based on the confirmed financial statements of the applicant company and supporting materials must necessarily be verified.

※ The amount of investment attraction is based on the actually completed paid-in investment from external professional investment institutions, and related evidence must necessarily be submitted (※Only achievements confirmed with evidence are recognized).

• (Scale of Designation) Selection evaluation (document→presentation) / Final support for up to 2 companies

※ The scale of designation is confirmed only for '26 and can be changed depending on the evaluation and deliberation results.

※ About 50% of the applicant companies can be selected for follow-up (presentation) evaluation through document evaluation.

■ Designation Procedure

◦ The review procedure proceeds with application, pre-screening, and selection evaluation (document·presentation).

Announcement, Promotion, and Application Submission '26. 9. 9. ~ 10. 2.	▶	Pre-screening Early October '26	▶	Selection Evaluation (Document·Presentation Evaluation) ~November '26	▶	Result Announcement and Designation Certificate Award Ceremony ~December '26
Special Zone Foundation·Research Institute Companies		Special Zone Promotion Foundation		Evaluation Committee		Ministry of Science and ICT·Special Zone Foundation

※ The above schedule may change during the process.

Ⅲ Support Contents for Designated Companies

■ Common Support

◦ (Dedicated Support) The designated dedicated staff of the special zone foundation (regional special zone) provides linkage and growth support consulting of special zone projects·enterprise support programs according to the growth stage and demand of companies.

◦ (Network Building) Support exchange and cooperation between Rising Star·Star·Honorary Research Institute Companies utilizing research institute company network programs such as 'Research Institute Company Night'.

- Share excellent growth cases by growth stage, roundtables, mentoring and open innovation linkage·support between senior-junior research institute companies.

◦ (Promotion Support) Provide priority support for company·product promotion at major domestic and international events such as research and development special zone outcome exchange meetings, science festivals, overseas exhibitions.

- Connect online·offline promotions including media for dissemination of achievements of outstanding research institute companies.

◦ (Issuance of Designation Certificate) Award a separate outstanding (Rising Star, Star) research institute company designation certificate in the name of the Vice Prime Minister and Minister of Science and ICT for external promotion and credibility enhancement of companies designated by growth stage.

※ Detailed support contents and support timing may change depending on the promotional situation and budget.

1. Support for Rising Star Research Institute Company

◦ **(R&BD linkage for technological capacity acquisition)**

- Early-stage technology scale-up R&BD* linked and prioritized support for R&D special zone development project

* Project name: '2027 Research Institute Company Strategic Cultivation Project,' support scale/duration: approximately 1.475 billion KRW/2.75 years (2027~2029)

※ This project supports the project in a total of 2 phases, selecting tasks with excellent growth through competition in each phase (selecting up to 50% of tasks for the next phase (from Phase 1 to Phase 2) through competition) and plans to provide linked support for the subsequent phase.

※ The scale of the support project has only been confirmed for 2027 and may be changed depending on the evaluation and review results and other circumstances.

- IP strategy consulting support in connection with relevant organizations such as the Korea Invention Promotion Association, Korea Patent Technology Promotion Agency (upon request)

◦ **(Investment and finance linkage)**

- Support for attracting private follow-up investments and linkage with investment programs such as special zone funds (upon request)

- Preferential recommendation and linkage with relevant programs, including exclusive special guarantees (Technology Credit Guarantee Fund), special zone acceleration, etc. (upon request)

※ The contents of the support do not guarantee the selection of individual support projects, such as R&BD linkage, investment, guarantees, consulting, etc., and each project must meet the support requirements and separate evaluation procedures.

◦ **(Market development)**

- Linkage to global advancement programs such as overseas IR and exhibitions (upon request)

- Recommendation and linkage of related support projects for entry into the public procurement market and expansion of sales channels (upon request)

2. Support for Star Research Institute Companies

◦ **(Scale-up R&BD linkage)**

- Linkage and prioritized support for large R&BD projects* and global PoC, such as R&D special zone development projects

* Project name: '2027 Strategic Technology Research Outcome Commercialization (Unicorn Project Phase 1),' support scale/duration: approximately 1.75 billion KRW for Phase 1 / 1.75 years

※ This project supports the project in a total of 3 phases, selecting tasks with excellent growth through competition in each phase (selecting up to 50% of tasks for the next phase (from Phase 1 to Phase 2 to Phase 3) through competition) and plans to provide linked support for the subsequent phase.

※ The scale of the support project has only been confirmed for 2027 and may be changed depending on the evaluation and review results and other circumstances.

◦ (Regulatory compliance) Identifying regulatory difficulties arising during the corporate growth process and providing regulatory improvement support in connection with regulatory sandboxes in R&D special zones (upon request)

◦ (Demonstration and certification support) Support for product and service demonstration and certification linked with demonstration scale-up projects and public research institutes (upon request)

◦ (EXIT support) Support for sustainable growth and market independence by linking with IPO preparation consulting, M&A related support programs, etc. (upon request)

※ The contents of the support do not guarantee the selection of individual support projects, such as R&BD task linkage, investment, guarantees, consulting, etc., and each project must meet the support requirements and separate evaluation procedures.

Ⅳ Application period and method

■ Application period

◦ 2026. 9. 9 (Wed) ~ 2026. 10. 2 (Fri), until 16:00

※ Applications submitted after the closing time will not be accepted.

■ Application method

◦ Online submission via email

- Submission email: inno-tat@innopolis.or.kr

■ Submission documents

◦ Only documents issued within 3 months from the date of announcement are accepted.

Category	Submission documents	Remarks
Mandatory	① Application form for designation as an excellent research institute company by growth stage	Appendix No. 1
	② Business plan	Appendix No. 2
	③ Business registration certificate	Copy
	④ Certificate of all corporate registration entries	Within 3 months from the date of announcement
	⑤ Standard financial statements for the last 3 years ('23~'25) (balance sheet, income statement, detailed statements*) *Details on cost of manufacturing, changes in intangible assets (development costs) statement, etc.	Only financial statements stamped by the National Tax Service or a tax accountant are recognized.
	⑥ Certificate of national and local tax payment	Valid as of the date of announcement
	⑦ Consent form for the collection and use of personal and company information	Appendix No. 3

	⑧ Statement of eligibility and participation commitment	Appendix No. 4
If applicable	⑨ Proof of investment attraction performance	Such as investment contracts
	⑩ Proof of technological capability certification	Confirmation of venture company, NET·NEP certification, CES innovation awards, etc.
	⑪ Proof of intellectual property rights (e.g., registered patent certificate)	Applicable company
	⑫ Proof of business performance such as sales, export, employment, etc.	Applicable company
Optional	⑬ Company introduction materials and IR Deck, etc.	Optional submission

※ To verify the factual relationship of submitted materials during the preliminary review and evaluation process, additional supporting materials may be requested ※ If it is difficult to confirm eligibility or achievements based solely on the submitted materials, the achievements may not be recognized.

V	Selection procedure and evaluation criteria	

■ Implementation procedure

Procedure	Main contents	Schedule (tentative)
Project announcement and application ▼	Recruitment of applicant companies and receipt of application documents	By 10/2 (Fri)
Preliminary review ▼	Review of eligibility, quantitative criteria, submitted materials, and financial soundness	By 10/15 (Thu)
Document evaluation ▼	Evaluation focused on the current capabilities and growth foundation of the company (※ Selected approximately double the number of companies for presentation evaluation)	By 10/23 (Mon)
Presentation evaluation ▼	In-depth evaluation of business performance, growth potential, and domestic and international market expansion possibilities	By 11/13 (Fri)
Result review ▼	Comprehensive review and confirmation of final designated companies based on evaluation results	~11/20(Fri)
Notification of results ▼	Individual notice of designation results	~11/27(Fri)
Issuance of designation certificate	Issuance of designation certificate for laboratory corporations by growth stage	In December

※ The above schedule is subject to change depending on evaluation and promotion status ※ If necessary during the evaluation process, additional materials submission and fact verification may be requested

■ Evaluation Criteria

1. Rising Star Laboratory Corporation

◦ (Document evaluation) Selection of companies subject to presentation evaluation focusing on the current foundation of growth, such as technology and product power and corporate capability

◦ (Presentation evaluation) In-depth evaluation focusing on future growth potential such as business feasibility, marketability, and scalability (※ The presentation is fundamentally made by the representative)

Category	Main contents	Weight (%)	
		Document	Presentation
Growth potential and corporate capability	• Recent sales growth, investment attraction, employment trends, etc. • Business promotion capability of the management and expertise of technical personnel • Commercialization execution capability in research and development, production, sales, etc. • Commercialization performance within the last 3 years and market verification level	25	20
Technological growth and innovation	• Conformity with the purpose of laboratory corporation system and Rising Star designation • Differentiation, innovation, and versatility of the technology possessed • Technical completeness and competitiveness of products/services	40	35

Marketability and business model feasibility	• Target market size, growth, and entry potential • Specificity of analysis for customers, demand sources, and competing products • Feasibility of revenue model, pricing strategy, and sales channel securing strategy	35	45
Total		100	100

2. Star Laboratory Corporation

◦ (Document evaluation) Evaluation focusing on confirmed growth achievements to date, such as investment attraction, sales, exports, and corporate capability

◦ (Presentation evaluation) In-depth evaluation focusing on future scaling-up potential such as market expansion, follow-up investment, and growth potential of anchor companies (※ The presentation is fundamentally made by the representative)

Category	Main contents	Weight (%)	
		Document	Presentation
Commercialization performance and growth	• Business performance such as sales, employment, export, investment attraction over the past three years • Sustainability of sales volume and growth trends • Level of market verification of products/services and status of securing major customers/demand sources	20	20
Global and large market expansion potential	• Size, growth, and entry potential of global or large markets • Specificity of overseas expansion strategies, plans for responding to local certifications/regulations, and global partnerships • Potential for creating global commercialization achievements such as exports, overseas PoC, and overseas technology transfer	45	40

Feasibility of EXIT and corporate growth roadmap	• Specificity of the EXIT roadmap such as IPO, M&A, strategic investment attraction • Feasibility of corporate value enhancement strategy and follow-up investment attraction plans • Challenging nature of growth goals and appropriateness of stagewise promotion plans	35	40
Total		100	100

■ Final Selection

◦ Selection for presentation evaluation of roughly twice the desired designation size according to the document evaluation

◦ Comprehensive selection of final stage-wise companies based on pre-screening of application qualifications, quantitative criteria, document evaluation, and presentation evaluation results

◦ In the case of a tie or as necessary, the priority can be determined by the higher score of the "Marketability and business model feasibility" evaluation item for Rising Star and "Feasibility of EXIT and corporate growth roadmap" evaluation item for Star

※ If it is determined that there are insufficient companies that meet the purpose of the designated evaluation result, fewer companies than planned may be designated

■ Application and Exclusion from Designation

◦ Eligibility review and pre-support exclusion subjects: subjects restricted by Article 19 of the 'Operational Management Guidelines for Research and Development Special Zone Promotion Projects' will be excluded from designation

Submission of documentary evidence related to risk verification	■ Standard financial statements for the fiscal years 2023-2025 issued by the National Tax Service (Home Tax) or an audit report

※ However, if issues arise with the debt ratio, current ratio due to the application of Korea-International Financial Reporting Standards (K-IFRS), or if full capital impairment occurs, General Enterprises Accounting Principles (K-GAAP) may be applied to determine the debt ratio, current ratio, and full capital impairment possibility. In such cases, the applying laboratory corporation must submit additional documents according to accounting standards to a professional institution for determination of debt ratio and current ratio, and mixed application of Korea-International Financial Reporting Standards and General Enterprises Accounting Principles is not allowed

※ If it is confirmed that after the selection evaluation, an entity falls under the restrictions specified in Article 19 of the 'Operational Management Guidelines for Research and Development Special Zone Promotion Projects', the designated designation may be canceled or the R&D project agreement may be terminated

◦ If any of the following cases apply, exclusion from evaluation or cancellation of designation even after selection may occur

1) If the laboratory corporation registration was canceled or registration requirements were not maintained as of the announcement deadline

2) If the company does not meet the application qualifications or minimum quantitative criteria for each growth stage

3) If it is confirmed that the application form and submitted documents were falsely completed or falsified, forged

4) If the company did not submit required documents or eligibility could not be confirmed with the submitted documents

5) If the company is under regulation due to default with a financial institution or similar

6) Companies in arrears of national or local taxes

7) If it is judged that normal corporate activities are difficult due to corporate bankruptcy, suspension, closure, or full capital impairment

8) If the company or its representative is subject to restrictions on participation in national research and development projects or subject to sanctions according to related laws and regulations

9) If engaged in or intending to engage in businesses under the industry classification of Article 4 of the Enforcement Decree of the Small and Medium Enterprises Startup Support Act (company)

10) If recognized as significantly not aligning with the designation purpose by the Ministry of Science and ICT or the Research and Development Special Zone Promotion Foundation

※ The exclusion from support and designation is, in principle, determined based on the reception deadline, and if the related facts are confirmed after designation, the designation may be canceled

■ Notes

◦ Applications must be submitted via email (inno-tat@innopolis.or.kr) only

◦ Applicants must fully verify the application qualifications, designation criteria, and submission documents in this public notice before applying

◦ Applicants can only apply for one category between Rising Star or Star laboratory corporation

◦ Submitted applications and documents will not be returned

◦ It is possible to verify the factual relationship between the information stated in the application and the submitted proof materials during the evaluation process, and additional document submission or on-site verification may be requested if necessary

◦ If it is confirmed that the contents of the application differ from the facts or the submitted documents are false, forged, or altered, the application will be excluded from evaluation and the designation will be canceled even after confirmation

◦ Evaluation details and specific matters such as the scores given by each evaluation committee member may not be disclosed

◦ The designated companies must cooperate by submitting necessary materials for the investigation of growth outcomes, performance management, and publicity conducted by the Research and Development Special Zone Promotion Foundation in the future

◦ If there is a failure to meet the registration requirements of a laboratory corporation or significant changes in designation requirements occur, designation may be canceled in accordance with related procedures

◦ Support under this announcement for R&D, investment, finance, market development, and global expansion may change according to each business project's budget and plan, and separate application and evaluation is required for projects requiring it

◦ Designation may be canceled in the event of intentional or negligent imitation, plagiarism, or misuse of others' or companies' plans

◦ Other unspecified matters in this announcement adhere to the guidelines and procedures of the Ministry of Science and ICT and the Research and Development Special Zone Promotion Foundation

◦ On the application deadline, delays or disruptions due to heavy reception loads may occur, so pre-application is recommended, and post-deadline submissions are impossible (※ Submission deadline ~10/2(Fri), strictly observe 16:00 (KST))

■ Contact (responsible department): Technology Diffusion Team, Business Headquarters, Research and Development Special Zone Promotion Foundation

◦ Business inquiry contact: Yujin Baek, Researcher, Technology Diffusion Team

◦ Contact details: yjin807@innopolis.or.kr / 042-865-8951

※ Appendix 1. Application form for designation of excellent laboratory corporations by growth stage in 2026

Appendix 2. Business plan for designation of excellent laboratory corporations by growth stage in 2026

Appendix 3. Consent form for collection and use of personal and corporate information

Appendix 4. Appropriateness of application eligibility and participation pledge